RICHARD STRAUSS
"*Ruhe* ***meine*** seele"

Thoughts on the Opportunity *Within Contradiction*

Alexander Goodhart

From the outset of *Vier Lieder,* Strauss chooses a subtly dramatic subject, one that can be difficult to discern from its harmonic language alone but is clear in its lyrics; it is a drama born out of paradox: the tension between the eponymous *"Rest"* and the narrator's *lack* of rest. We can discern this instinctively through the title alone: ***Rest, My Soul***– rendered less than restful with the added exclamation point!

Thus, from a dramatical perspective, the cycle begins in a place of *unrest*. It would be difficult to ignore this in performance practice; one would have to work against the near-total dearth of *"*restful*"* moments. But of what character is this state? Disturbance? Trepidation? Anxiety? And how, too, can the *rest* be illustrated– even in absentia, on the horizon? Here is where astute sense for its harmonic language helps reveal the possibilities.

Ruhe, meine Seele begins with an embodiment of this duality.

– Its chords are rich: darkly affected in their close voicing in the piano's graveled lower range.

– Their relationships are obscure and unmoored.

but,

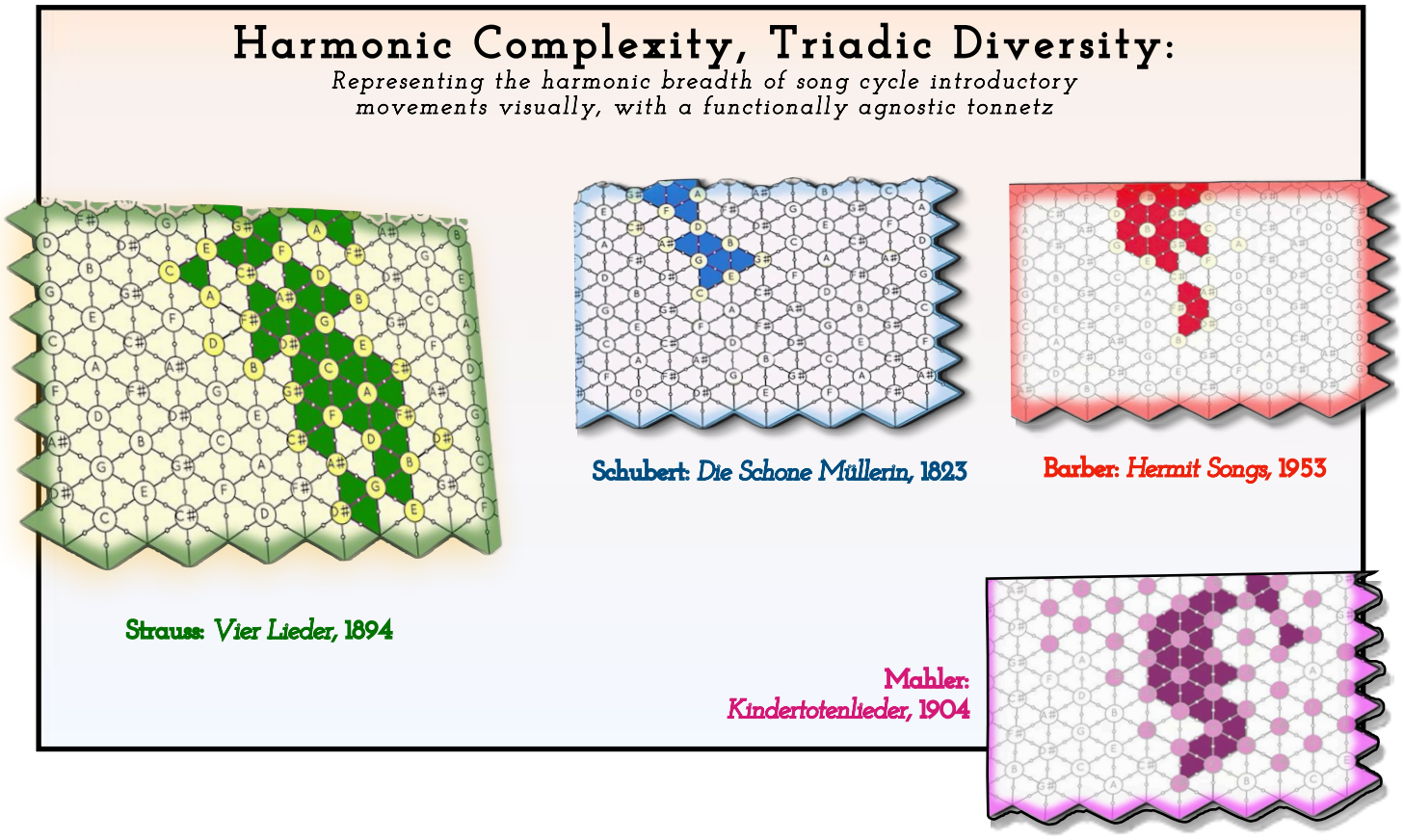
– They begin with a simple repetition of two.

– Their rhythm is slow and regular.

That repetition– a "rocking" oscillation between two chords which introduces the cycle– is an interesting technique pointing towards the lulling comfort of rest. It is packed with information

that makes for the multifaceted metaphor: the dream of peace in a state of distress. But elucidating this information concretely is challenging: the music relies on widely agreed-upon theoretical conventions as often as it flouts them.

A combination of functional harmony, Schenkerian deconstruction, neo-Riemannian transformation, and- perhaps- a dash of whimsy, would prove necessary in speaking decisively about the organizational structures. This is due to the systemically florid manner in which harmony and form is approached in the composition. Though metaphorical and generalized descriptions are often more readily digestible when considering interpretation, it can be noted briefly that theoretical breakdowns can be just as illustrative. For example, the neo-Riemannian model provides a visual way to see in one glance the significant harmonic terrain this short movement travails:



The raw amount of chords and key areas, what results from their juxtaposition and how to label their connection are academically-oriented challenges that may not satisfy a search for unifying interpretations.

However, returning to that harmonic oscillation of the first two measures, the harmony does reveal a grounding contextual comparison that can be of true assistance to the analytic performer. Those darkly voiced sonorities provide two simple triadic chords: C7 and F#m7 (both in inversion). The common tone between the two, E, is the lowest of the voicing and the only voice without motion in this introductory passage. ***A digression:*** *texturally, Strauss is highlighting the contrapuntal facet in spite of its homorhythmic density. Perhaps, just as the precarious relation is linked through it, the performer would bridge their audience into the sound world with an accent+tenuto approach to the low E.*

The irreconcilable nature of these two chords *is the* grounding our performances can profit from. A tritone relation can be a type of evaded predominant, ask any jazzer, but we would need to see that chord fitting in with what follows in a convincing way. Here is what does follow, in the first vocal phrase, and a conjectured analysis of how each one may belong to either the key of F (as implied by the C dominant seventh) or in F# (as implied by the fourth measure's C# dominant seventh):

	Analyzed in F:	Analyzed in F#:
C 7	V 7 ✓	N65/ iv
F#m 7	vii ø7 #5 / ii	i 7 ✓
C 7	V 7 ✓	N 65 / iv
F#m 7	vii ø7 #5 / ii	i 7 ✓
D ø7	vii ø7 / ♭VII	vii ø7 / VI ✓
C♯7	V 7 / ♭ii	V 7 ✓
F♯ 7	V 7 / ♭V	V 7 / IV ✓
B 7	V 7 / VII ♮5	V 7 / ♭VII ✓

This opening phrase pivots from ambiguity to solidly belonging to a key more closely related to F# than to F. The piece doesn't observe this strictly, however. The following phrase, which begins with the titular lyric, begins with a succession of C7, Gm7, and A7– or, in other words, V7, ii7, V7/vi, if we reframe with an F major tonic. It seems that F was not a deceitful implication in the song's first chord.

The meaning of the music must be considered, too, to validate if the harmonic extrapolation is . The stanzas comprise the following:

Nicht ein Lüftchen,	Rest, my soul
Regt sich leise,	Not even
Sanft entschlummert	A soft breeze stirs,
Ruht der Hain;	In gentle sleep
Durch der Blätter	The wood rests;
Dunkle Hülle	Through the leaves'
Stiehlt sich lichter	Dark veil
Sonnenschein.	Bright sunshine
	Steals.
Ruhe, ruhe,	
Meine Seele,	Rest, rest,
Deine Stürme	My soul,
Gingen wild,	Your storms
Hast getobt und	Were wild,
Hast gezittert,	You raged and
Wie die Brandung,	You quivered,
Wenn sie schwillt!	Like the breakers,
	When they surge!
Diese Zeiten	
Sind gewaltig,	These times
Bringen Herz und	Are violent,
Hirn in Not—	Cause heart and
Ruhe, ruhe,	Mind distress—
Meine Seele,	Rest, rest,
Und vergiß,	My soul,
Was dich bedroht!	And forget!

The harmonic progression of ***Ruhe, meine Seele,*** is one aspect that illustrates the thematics' emotional breadth in a literal manner: it sits among other opportunities and challenges for the performer to reconcile dichotomous elements. There are unique harmonic inventions in each of its sections, and the rhythmic, metrical, and contrapuntal content of those sections, too, transform and focus on new areas of invention (undermining the song's strophic nature, a diffusive effect).

We will continue to focus solely on the first phrase as an invitation for the performers to approach these rich and layered sections with awoken and unbiased senses.

As the listener is immediately drawn into its ambiguity through Strauss's application of chromaticism, the establishment of F# is made clear by the first statement's ending on its dominant. This illustrates the advantage a performer may reap when interpreting the music with some deference to these competing themes. The dichotomy between that eerie and murky tremulousness and the stability of a promised key is, also, a mirror and enhancement of the the text:

"*Rest, my soul. Not even a soft breeze stirs, in* **gentle sleep the wood rests;**

Through the leaves' *dark veil,* **bright sunshine** *steals."*

Here, we have the familiar bucolic nature the Romanticism of Germany often invoked. But there is subtle contradiction: in such a gentle realm of sleep, why is the soul in need of coaxing in order to relax? Why does the air not move? Why is the shade characterized as something without light, some thing that conceals? And why is the glimmer of sun's warmth a thief?

Just as F# is both a place of rest and an incongruence, repose is only partially actualized: the speaker is perturbed in the wake of forest slumber.

However, much of this paradoxical and unsettled nature lies beneath the artifice. While difficult to contextualize analytically, Strauss is still using chords of limited complexity, and their successions observe root movement of intervallic clarity. This provides the listener with an unthreatening and familiar sound world, even if pollenated by despair. The held bass in measures 1-4 is an another example of the purposeful amelioration of discomfort for the audience. It is not hard to convey effectively to an audience the raw power of these lush chords and of the vocalist's eruptive turns from recitative cadential implications to soaring, unexpected bellows.

What is gained from bringing out the confusion or contradictions here, and where should one seek to employ them? For clarity, an enumeration:

– The title, "Rest, my soul!" – the plaintive urging of softness with the marking of urgency.

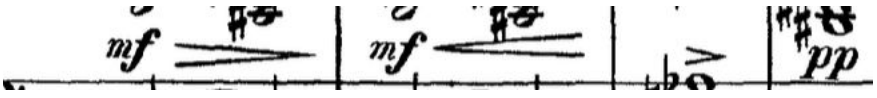
– Chordal texture with contrapuntal voicing

– Well-justified home key that is best signaled by its dominant and related strongly with tritone neighbors

– A peaceful sleeping environment marked by subtle threats and malevolence

Perhaps a keen way to bring this *reverie in mild turmoil* to life is to subvert and reverse its affect. For all the keyboard's harmonic acrobatics, the singers line here is Classically simple in its pitch content: an ascending major scale shifts to a ♭7, which resolves exactly as that would for most at least the past century before its composition.

Naturally, then, the pianist can embody tumult; the composer indicates enough in the dynamic content the music opens with:



Yet, if we are convinced at all that contradiction and duality play a strong role in the work's conception, we need not limit that to the dichotomy observed in comparing the players to each other. They can also be compared to themselves: that is, they, too can embody certain contradictions.

This goes along with the enveloping and continuous nature of the music: it is not a work that pivots in affect, despite its frequent pivots in lyrics, harmony, melodic contour, etc. By diffusing contradictions from moments and stratification to the motivic fibers woven through the music, we support both the Romantic sound of Strauss and the nuanced uniqueness of the work. The soloist could sing their slow and scalar ascents with unexpected tension, with more palpable energy at the phrases' outset than its apex. The pianist can put their effort into interpreting the dynamic undulations on a per-voice basis, and subduing the easily-obtained tolling strikes that some of the accented ten-note chords imply.

Strauss's harmonic duality presents extensive interpretive possibilities. Performers must manage the transitions between keys with precision to the text's emotional progression, utilizing tempo rubato and phrasing to accentuate the contrasts and connections between tonal regions. For instance, the shift from F to Bb in Phrase II can be emphasized with a marked dynamic crescendo, while the final resolution on C might be approached with a sense of perceived determinism, as though the harmony has achieved a state of equilibrium rather than resolution.

Performers can, through any number of approaches, animate the song's embedded duality, and in doing so may elevate their performance and their audience's experience. For such densely emotive music, this perspective gives the musicians a through-line that offers both a unique interpretive modality and the ability to find, in all manner of gesture, a unifying force.